



WORKSHOP

**LEVERAGING
EVIDENCE FOR
EFFECTIVE
ANTICIPATORY
ACTION**

**OUTCOME
DOCUMENT**



20-21 APRIL 2026



**FAO Headquarters in Rome:
Austria room & online**

150+

**Online &
in-person
participants**

50+

Speakers

10+

Sessions

Background

The "*Leveraging Evidence for Effective Anticipatory Action*" workshop, held at FAO Headquarters in Rome, Italy, brought together over **70** researchers, practitioners, and donors from UN agencies, Member countries, academic institutions, and NGOs/NPOs to advance the evidence agenda for anticipatory action (AA) in agrifood systems. The two-day event, convened by FAO's **Agrifood Economics and Policy Division** (ESA) and the **Office of Emergencies and Resilience** (OER), was held in a hybrid format, with more than 100 concurrent viewers joining online. The workshop combined technical sessions, field case studies, and cross-institutional dialogue, with the aim of identifying what works, for whom, and under what conditions, and how evidence can more effectively inform AA programming and investment decisions.

Key Themes and Findings

The workshop covered several key themes over the two days, ranging from the state of evidence in AA (1) to the translation of evidence into practice (2), increasing collaboration across stakeholders involved in evidence generation and programme implementation (3), and innovative financing and the role of donors and national governments to support these efforts (4). The overall atmosphere was one of agreement; agreement on need for more evidence generation, with a strong **call for collective actions**. Discussions were collaborative and constructive, participants gained valuable insights, and concrete next steps were agreed upon.

The following provides an overview of the key discussion points under each theme:

1. Evidence, Analytics, and Decision Support: What We Know and What We Don't

A central discussion across the two days focused on the current state of evidence for anticipatory action (AA) and the extent to which existing findings can support programming and investment decisions at scale. The first keynote speaker Dr. Karen Macours (Paris School of Economics/J-PAL) highlighted that while the evidence base for AA was expanding, it remained concentrated. Cash transfers delivered before shocks perform at least as well as, and often better than, post-shock assistance, particularly for food security and mental well-being. However, the evidence remains heavily skewed toward flood contexts and cash modalities, with significantly less known about drought, in-kind support, or multi-hazard settings.

The need to move beyond asking "does it work?" toward understanding how and under what conditions it works, focusing on transfer modality, timing, targeting, and the role of information alongside material support, was a recurring theme across sessions.

A central theme across both days was the tension between research rigour and humanitarian needs. **Generating rigorous evidence in crisis settings is possible and urgent** but requires methodological soundness and sometimes flexibility in research designs.

The second keynote speaker, Dr. Dean Karlan (Northwestern University/IPA), emphasized the need for honest conversations about evidence gaps while cautioning audience about the systemic barriers that prevent rigorous research from translating into policy and programming decisions. He also highlighted the **importance of long-term follow-up in evaluations** and stressed the challenge of generating cost-effectiveness evidence that satisfies both research rigor and accountability needs for donors.

Another key area of discussion during the workshop was the **role of forecasting and decision support systems**. While presentations showcased significant advances through innovative and cutting-edge tools, the conversation also highlighted remaining challenges in effectively supporting anticipatory action, particularly in translating probabilistic forecasts into impact-based triggers, integrating diverse data sources, and sustaining reliable data pipelines in data-scarce environments. Overall, it was emphasized that technical innovations alone are insufficient; equal attention must be given to strengthening institutional uptake, clarifying trigger mechanisms, and building trust between researchers and implementers.

Overall, the technical discussion on evidence generation highlighted encouraging progresses for strengthening implementation underscoring the **importance of better aligning what researchers produce with what can be effectively implemented in the field** and suggesting that closing this gap requires not only more robust evidence, but also better-aligned incentives and deeper trust among stakeholders.

2. Coordination, data sharing and tackling field challenges as prerequisites for scale

Participants acknowledged that agencies too often evaluate a single AA intervention in isolation, without taking into consideration that multiple interventions might be simultaneously ongoing and target the same beneficiaries, particularly in protracted crises, and thus making it challenging to attribute outcomes to a specific intervention. Data protection constraints were acknowledged as another significant barrier, particularly for joint evaluations as well as the use of different evaluation methodologies.

Concrete practical next steps discussed included the development of shared outcome frameworks, common data-sharing arrangements, and funding approaches that reward collaborative learning over siloed reporting. This approach could be piloted in selected priority countries where pre-existing conditions (such as field presence, ongoing projects and similar evaluations) are conducive to collaboration and hence, test joint evaluations. The overall priority identified across the two days was the criticality of building a **shared and common learning agenda**, where each evaluation contributes to a cumulative and comparable evidence base, was identified as a priority.

Moreover, practitioners and country-level actors underscored the risk of a disconnection between evidence generation and operational realities on the ground. Challenges of timeliness, beneficiary targeting in complex crisis settings, community trust, and integration of AA into national government systems remain significant.

3. Donor Expectations and Member Perspectives

Member countries and other multilateral partners provided direct feedback on the evidence gaps that may require further investigation in order to scale political and financial support for AA. Representatives from the the European Union, the governments of Belgium, Germany, Norway, The Philippines, and the United Kingdom, agreed on the fact that anticipatory action has moved beyond the pilot phase and expressed overall consensus about the relevance and value added of AA, which should prompt more investments to reach scale while at the same time continuing to learn by tackling unanswered questions. Donors also called for more transparent cost-effectiveness analysis, stronger connections between anticipatory action and resilience and development programming, as well as between AA and emergency response.

4. Disaster Risk Financing and Innovative Finance

The workshop highlighted the strikingly low coverage of people in need by anticipatory action despite recent growth in the prearranged financing landscape. Prearranged financing for disasters has grown to USD 9.4 billion globally (as of 2024). Funding for anticipatory action specifically has also grown significantly over the past years, but it remains a small fraction of this prearranged disaster finance.

Specialists in disaster risk financing (DRF) highlighted the importance of layering financial instruments, including pooling risks for insurance purposes, contingent credit, and crisis modifiers in development programmes, as a priority for ensuring resources are available when triggers are reached. The underutilised potential of crisis modifiers, which allow longer-term development programmes to pivot in an anticipatory way, was identified as a promising pathway to scale without creating parallel structures.

Way Forward

The two days of discussion concluded with a strong call for collective action, from which participants identified five concrete next steps.

These commitments are intended to be tracked and revisited as part of a continued inter-agency learning process.

01 - Launch a shared evidence agenda

A living document co-owned by agencies, researchers, and donors that prioritises evidence questions, assigns leads, and tracks methodological commitments.

02 - Harmonise outcome variables and evaluation quality benchmarks

Agree on a core set of outcome indicators and minimum quality standards for AA evaluations across organisations to enable cross-study synthesis and build a credible collective evidence base.

03 - Integrate AA within the Disaster Risk Management cycle

Leverage the potential of anticipatory action to connect humanitarian and development/resilience objectives and finance, embedding AA within national DRM systems rather than parallel structures.

04 - Commit to and populate the Anticipation Hub

Formally commit to contributing beneficiary and intervention data to the Anticipation Hub's open architecture, enabling de-duplication and joint evaluation design across agencies at country level.

05 - Commission an interagency cost-effectiveness study

Build on existing Anticipation Hub-funded work to produce a multi-agency cost-effectiveness comparison using a shared methodology, attracting dedicated research funding separate from programme budgets to build donor confidence.